

Episode 177: *Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes – Part 4

Various productions are moving toward spring at each company, and even someone like me has been invited to work on several April-start projects. One of them was announced the other day: *Saint Seiya Omega* (聖闘士星矢 Ω). It's a completely new original TV series.

Actually, when rumours of "doing Saint Seiya" were floating around last year, it felt like someone else's business, but surprisingly the offer came to me, and honestly I was shocked. Even so, if it had been a remake I was thinking of declining, but since it's a new story - and original at that - I decided I wanted to help out.

Even so, everyone's new staff! Incredibly, I'm the only staff member remaining from the original series! (laugh)

And it's tough (laugh). After all, it airs in April! Ah, there's no time...

But anyway, I'll do my best! Please support us!

Now then.

Episode 2: Dangerous Survival Strategy Storyboard & Direction/Yamazaki Mitsue (山崎みつえ), Colour Direction/Otsuka Natsuko (大塚奈津子)

Episode 3: And Then Eat Me Magnificently... Storyboard & Direction/Shibata Katsunori (柴田勝紀), Colour Direction/Akimoto Yuki (秋元由紀)

With Princess of the Crystal's descent providing the "Penguindrum" clue, the Takakura siblings begin pursuing Oginome Ringo (荻野目苹果). Remotely controlling the penguins, they proceed with tailing Ringo and investigating her personal life, but Ringo actually makes contact with the Takakura siblings' homeroom teacher, Tabuki (多路).

Moreover, she goes under the floor of the apartment room where Tabuki lives. It's revealed that Ringo is Tabuki's stalker. Such was Episode 2.

The Takakura brothers infiltrate the Oginome house while Ringo is away. But Ringo returns home unexpectedly early. Every 20th of the month is curry day, so Ringo makes curry and visits Tabuki's room, but there's a beautiful woman there making curry and waiting for Tabuki to return. Ringo switches her curry for the pot, but on the way home, through an unfortunate accident, she gets covered head-to-toe with a pot full of curry. And when the Takakura brothers return home, there's Ringo sitting at the dinner table, having been helped by Himari (陽毬). Such was Episode 3.

Rewinding time to February 2011. Work on Episode 2 began, considerably behind the original schedule. According to records, the art meeting for Episode 2 was in early February. Originally we planned to create a "reserve" of 8 episodes by broadcast start... but in reality it was half that, 4 episodes.

Episodes 2 and 3 were still in the period when we were building up the initial story settings in parallel.

First, the school uniforms. In the main story, Kanba (冠葉) and Shoma (晶馬) are often in school uniforms, but the design of those uniforms went through quite a winding path to decision.

The chest emblem and such were in Hoshino's character designs from the beginning, but in the initial design there was no red line division on the collar, and it was a blazer with a relatively ordinary silhouette. We were also exploring the animation shading for the blazer itself - whether to do normal/shadow animation or highlight/normal. Since the blazer colour itself would be blackish, we concluded that adding shadows in animation wouldn't be very effective, so we decided on highlight animation with no shadows. Then further changes during main production work. Initially we added highlight colour divisions to the red lines too, but it became "kind of noisy," so during Episode 2's main production work it was changed.

What was quite troublesome when deciding the blazer colour was the problem of the character main line (outline) colours. In *Mawaru Penguindrum*, we worked with basic main line colours of RGB: 33.33.36. Roughly black, or rather dark grey. Incidentally, the black (BL) during colouring was set to RGB: 8.8.8. Conversely, the eye white colour was RGB: 240.240.240. Actually, long ago during my Toei era, I was the one who set Toei productions' main line colour to RGB: 33.24.32 charcoal grey (it's still used now. *Pretty Cure* and such should be using it too), and initially I was thinking of using that main line colour for *Mawaru Penguindrum* too. However, while it had good compatibility with Kanba's hair, it was somewhat off with Shoma's blue hair, or was too strong for the balance against Himari and Ringo's skin tones - various things started bothering me, so after consideration I set it to 33.33.36.

This main line colour is actually in the somewhat bright category for this type of anime's main line colours. Looking at other works, there are some with 3.3.3 which is surprising... So in terms of area ratio it tends to appear whitish and float. But I deliberately went through with this density for the sake of compatibility with skin tones. And compatibility with the blazer paint colours. Not too buried, not too assertive - I think it achieved a good balance. Of course, matching with background art is also important. I think this problem also settled into a very good balance.

Oh yes, about the uniforms. Making the pants red was an idea Director Ikuhara had proposed from quite early on, and that direction was fine, but Director Ikuhara wanted to make the red saturation of those pants extremely high, and ultimately I put a stop to it saying "That's going too far!" and we settled on the current balance.

Speaking of pants, about the colour design of Kanba and Shoma's casual clothes - Kanba's casual pants somehow had a coloured jeans image. And on the day I was creating that colour, what Director Ikuhara wore to the studio was exactly that colour of Kanba's casual pants. "I'll take it!" so we used it as is (laugh). When I revealed this during colour checking, the director didn't seem to mind (laugh). So Kanba's pants = the director's casual wear.

I remember Ringo's sailor uniform being difficult. Honestly, no matter what colour you bring, someone somewhere has definitely done it. There's a destiny that sailor uniforms will inevitably resemble something. So Ringo's green - when we were stuck on the decision, either Director Ikuhara or Nishii gave the hint "How about green?" and it came together like that. Initially we were trying light blue and such. But that bright green was a big hit. It had such a green apple feel and became a good colour that defined her impression.

When Ringo's sailor uniform was decided, I immediately had an image for her two classmates in Episode 2. I had decided from the start that Yukina (雪菜) would be the gross face type, and when I actually showed everyone, it was highly praised. It's just regrettable that she had few appearance scenes (laugh).

Now Episode 2. And Episode 3.

For both episodes, without doing anything particularly special, we strived to be ordinary, carefully doing scene-by-scene colour design matching the dramatic time progression and backgrounds. As I wrote during Episode 1, the series-wide design plan was to build up colour design that would make the screen look as natural as possible until the middle part when the story would move significantly, so I have the impression we made it quite matter-of-factly. Particularly for Episode 2, following that impactful Episode 1, you want to do something, but I considered it important to deliberately take time to create and compile it "normally." Of course, the story itself was interesting from the start with that energy. So basically, we carefully built up special colouring matched to the art for each scene. Not just scene by scene, but in some cases we subtly changed things cut by cut. I didn't think I was being that detailed myself...

Episode 3's climax was definitely that evening scene and curry (laugh). That thick orange evening scene had an order to "make it feel like *Fist of the North Star*!" so both the art and colouring aimed exactly for that feel. However, that energy would be impossible for Himari's side (laugh), so the point was how we could make that transition.

Episode 2's colour direction was handled by Otsuka Natsuko. Following my previous work *The Tatami Galaxy* (四畳半神話大系), she participated in this work too as colour director. Episode 3 was Akimoto Yuki. She also participated following *The Tatami Galaxy*. For me, it's the best lineup. With me added, we planned to proceed with *Mawaru Penguindrum* in a basic three-person colour direction system. This was this work's "colour team." Due to two gross production episodes coming in, we ultimately added two more colour directors, but we operated with this small elite team throughout.

"Operating with as few staff as possible while maintaining precision" is actually an important point for TV series, especially continuous ones.

The advantage of few members is first that content explanation is easy (laugh). With new colour directors every time, you have to explain the work content each time, plus processing and prohibition explanations - it's quite troublesome, and there are often omissions. Next, your assigned episode count increases, allowing you to concentrate on content. This time too, everyone looked at storyboards for episodes other than their assigned ones, becoming thoroughly familiar with the content flow. If this becomes every other episode continuously, it becomes exhausting in today's TV production short-term battle schedules. Having them participate with such concentration means they can hold challenges for the next episodes in their minds, thinking about various things beyond what I'm considering to create colours, which I think is a good method in that respect too.

And above all, they thoroughly understand my methods (laugh). This is important, and especially for works with such quirks, having members who understand my tendencies is extremely grateful.

Now, during such Episodes 2 and 3. The art meeting for Episode 3 that began in the morning had ended, and we were having a late lunch when it happened. The Great East Japan Earthquake. March 11th. From that day, our production site would also be greatly affected.

(12.02.08)